

Dr. Hina Shah: An Unyielding Force for Women's Empowerment

In a world that often told her “no,” Dr. Hina Shah has forged her path to empower women everywhere with the power of “yes.” Her journey from resistance to revolution redefines what’s possible for women in business and beyond.

Dr. Hina Shah’s journey to economic independence began as a solitary path fraught with challenges. Hailing from a traditional background, her desire to be self-reliant defied societal norms. She pursued her goals undeterred by the lack of support from her family and community, choosing to believe in her vision of a world where women could thrive as independent entrepreneurs. Reflecting on her initial struggles, Dr. Shah once said, “When the world saw limits, I saw boundless potential.” Her resilience not only carried her through personal obstacles but also shaped her life’s work: empowering women to become financially independent and self-assured leaders.

In 1986, Dr. Shah’s vision crystalized with the founding of the International Center for Entrepreneurship and Career Development (ICECD). Through this pioneering institution, she committed to creating an equal environment where men and women contribute to economic growth through entrepreneurship. Over the past four decades, ICECD has become a transformative force, guiding thousands of women to break free from societal limitations. The institute’s holistic program integrates business planning, market research, finance, and production, while also cultivating resilience, mindset, and emotional readiness. This core program equips women with essential entrepreneurial skills, with options for targeted programs focused on specific areas as needed.

Her goal, Dr. Shah explains, has always been to “build a future where women are valued as equal partners, contributing to economic and social prosperity”. She elaborates, “Despite government efforts, many women remain unable to benefit due to the complex procedures involved. Furthermore, limited access to capital and a lack of awareness about entrepreneurship pose further hurdles. Overcoming these barriers is vital for achieving true gender equality within our community. It’s time for us to advocate for better support systems and resources to empower women entrepreneurs.”

One of ICECD’s flagship programs, the Women Entrepreneurship Development (WED) initiative, stands as



a testament to Dr. Shah’s innovative spirit. Initially tailored for urban areas, WED expanded across India, training women from all walks of life—including rural and tribal areas, widows, and women with disabilities. This flexible, part-time model has enabled countless women to balance business with family responsibilities, equipping them to thrive in business ownership. Today, WED’s reach spans the nation, igniting entrepreneurial potential among women who previously had limited opportunities.

Dr. Shah’s influence, however, extends well beyond India’s borders. Her Entrepreneurship Development Model has inspired programs in over 60 countries across Asia, Africa, the Caribbean, and the Pacific. With international partnerships and recognition as a “Center of Excellence” by the United Nations Economic and Social Commission

for Asia and the Pacific, ICECD’s programs have catalyzed billions in investments and created opportunities for millions of women worldwide. Her work with government entities like the Ministry of MSME and global organizations such as the World Bank and ILO has further amplified ICECD’s impact, driving a movement that combines economic empowerment with social reform.

Despite her many accolades, including the prestigious Stree Shakti Puraskar and the Gujarat Women Development Award, Dr. Shah’s mission is far from complete. Her vision is clear: to create “billion opportunities” for women. Through her determination and foresight, Dr. Hina Shah has transformed lives across generations, inspiring countless women to dream, lead, and conquer.